# Chapter 1

# Toward a Definition of Ekphrasis in Literature and Film

## Introduction

The classical figure of ekphrasis has become an increasingly popular critical concept in recent years. A keyword search on the MLA international bibliography results in 468 articles, book chapters, books, and dissertations, of which 177 were published in the last five years. Whereas traditionally ekphrasis was confined to poems that describe or analyze works of art, it is now generally accepted and used as a term that applies to all literary genres, that is, novel, drama, as well as essay. In spite of the expansion and popularity of this concept, however, it has not yet been applied to film. In the pages to follow I will contend that the concept of ekphrasis is applicable to film as well. Moreover, I will argue that ekphrasis can function as a useful tool to explore many of the issues at heart in the relationship between words and images which are central to the filmic discourse and the hybrid, collaborative nature of the cinematic medium.

The term ekphrasis is generally used to refer to works of poetry and prose that talk about or incorporate visual works of art. Definitions of ekphrasis, then, have been anchored traditionally in a particular modality: verbal discourses that directly verbalize one or more visual images, often discussed in terms of a power struggle between author and painter. Film's relationship with painting, although never discussed in terms of ekphrasis, has similarly been seen in terms of a competition: critics have traditionally rejected film's ability to do justice to art works and have accused film of not being true to the painting, of fragmenting it.[1] As I will show in this chapter as I outline the historical evolution of ekphrasis and current research on film-painting relationships, similar issues are at play in the relationships between literary texts and paintings, and films and paintings, but this connection has so far not been explored. This study investigates that missing dimension.

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1 André Bazin takes up this criticism and argues against it in his "Painting and Cinema", in *What is Cinema?* Trans. by Hugh Gray (Berkeley and Los Angeles: U of California P, 1967), pp.164-72 (esp. pp. 164-66).

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Whereas heretofore theorists have used ekphrasis to talk about the visual arts in poetry and prose, they have not identified the relationship between film and painting, or the triad of painting, novel and film, as similarly informed by an "ekphrastic ambition"[2] and the ways in which the resultant sender/receiver relationships reshape the reader or viewer perceptions of the artworks depicted. These relationships alter the social power and impact of the depicted art for the reader or viewer. In the chapters that follow I compare the verbal and visual characteristics of film and literary genres that depict art. By applying my expanded definition of ekphrasis as an interpretive tool, I demonstrate how different genres in either modality influence the way the reader or viewer reconstructs the implications of a work of art. In my conclusion I will suggest why, in the age of information and media influence, it becomes increasingly important to think beyond the traditional boundaries between visual and verbal arts as well as between academic disciplines, and I discuss the reason for what could be called critic's "ekphrastic fear" in films.[3]

## The Aesthetics of Ekphrasis

The Western discourse on ekphrasis has largely "developed under the auspices of Horace's comparison 'ut pictura poesis'"[4] a phrase which has often been misunderstood as an imperative rather than a comparison between the production of visual representations in poetry and in painting. A century after Horace, Plutarch cites a phrase by the 6th-century BCE writer, Simonide of Keos, that takes the comparison even further: "painting is mute poetry and poetry is a speaking picture."[5] Comparisons between poetry and painting are also made in Plato's *Republic* (Book X, 605) and Aristotle's *Poetics* (9.16-21). Plato banned all mimetic art from his *Republic*, because it makes

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2 Murray Krieger uses this term to describe the desire of the literary arts to "overcome the arbitrariness of the verbal sign by aping the natural sign of the visual arts." *Ekphrasis: The Illusion of the Natural Sign* (Baltimore and London: The Johns Hopkins UP, 1992), p. 14.

3 W.J.T. Mitchell discusses this term as critics' resistance against ekphrasis and its collapsing of the border between visual and verbal mediation in his "Ekphrasis and the Other," *Picture Theory* (Chicago and London: The U of Chicago P, 1994), pp. 154-56. Applied to film, I use this term to describe the resistance to ekphrasis and desire for purity in the two visual genres film and painting.

4 Antonella Braida, and Giuliana Pieri, introduction, *Image and Word: Reflections of Art and literature from the Middle Ages to the Present*. (Oxford: European Humanities Research Centre, 2003), pp. 1-14 (p. 3).

5 Henryk Markiewicz, "Ut Pictura Poesis: A History of the Topos and the Problem", *New Literary History* 18.3 (1987), 535-58 (p. 535).



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"phantoms that are very far removed from the truth," and is thus harmful to the soul.[6] Rescuing mimetic art from Plato's attack, Aristotle develops the parallel between poetry and painting further. He emphasizes that the object of both arts is the imitation of human nature in action, but their means are different: Poetry uses language, rhythm and harmony, while painting uses color and form.

Plato's followers have, for centuries, emphasized the "inferiority" of words to images with regard to their mimetic faithfulness of representation.[7] The rhetorical device of *enargeia* was thus a regular scholastic exercise of using words to create such a vivid, visual description that the object is placed before the listener's or reader's inner eye.[8] *Enargeia* also encompassed *ekphrasis* as a form of vivid evocation. Used as a rhetorical device, ekphrasis was defined in terms of its effect on an audience by Theon as "expository speech which vividly brings the subject before our eyes."[9] Like *enargeia*, ekphrasis marks the desire to overcome the arbitrariness of the verbal sign by aspiring to the natural sign of the visual arts.[10] One of the earliest and most famous examples of literary ekphrasis is Homer's description of Achilles' shield in book 18 of the *Iliad*, in which ekphrasis functions as a device to make the listeners re-create the shield in their minds' eyes.

During the Middle Ages, the "ut pictura poesis" formula remained popular, but its terms of comparison began to shift. Writers such as Augustine emphasized the greater difficulty of the reception of poetry, which made it more valuable than painting. Moreover, writing was also considered to be more capable of encompassing spiritual matters, and thus to have "greater moral and religious value" than painting, and to offer "more lasting satisfaction"[11]. This devaluation of painting is also reflected in its absence from the seven liberal arts, which consisted of the trivium (grammar, rhetoric, and dialectic), and the quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, astronomy and music). Painting and sculpture were considered manual rather than

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6 *The Republic of Plato*, ed., transl., and introd. by Allan Bloom (New York: Basic Books, 1968), p. 289.

7 Murray Krieger, *Ekphrasis: The Illusion of the Natural Sign* (Baltimore and London: The Johns Hopkins UP, 1992), p. 14.

8 Cf. Jean H. Hagstrum, *The Sister Arts: The Tradition of Literary Pictorialism and English Poetry from Dryden to Gray* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1958), p. 29; Krieger , p. 14.

9 William H. Race, "Ekphrasis", in *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, ed. by Alex Preminger and T.V.F. Brogan (Princeton, NJ: Princeton UP, 1993), pp. 320-321 (p. 320).

10 Cf. Krieger, pp. 10-12.

11 Markiewicz, p. 537.



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intellectual labor and therefore classified with the mechanical arts. In the centuries that followed, painters and sculptors struggled to combat their status as artisans and imitators, rather than artists and creators, and to reaffirm the intellectual nature of their work.

One of the first to counter that hierarchy was Leon Battista Alberti, whose treatise on art, *Della Pittura* (1435), reasserts the painter's primacy, as it is he who excites the imagination the most (cf. Braida and Pieri 5). Since Alberti, this contest for the representational superiority between the sister arts is know as *paragone*. In the Renaissance, it was Leonardo da Vinci who reclaimed the prominent place of the visual arts the most fervently in his *Paragone* (ca. 1510), reversing Simonides' comparison by claiming that if painting is "mute poetry," then poetry is "blind painting."[12] While Leonardo sought to prove the superiority of the visual arts over poetry, Lessing, in his *Laokoon* (1766), attempts to reverse that hierarchy by drawing strict boundaries between the representational realms of poetry and painting. Whereas poetry is best suited to represent actions in time due to the temporal nature of its reception, painting can only represent a single pregnant moment in space since it is perceived as a static object. In other words, Lessing distinguishes the creation of mental images in time from the static nature of the physical painting. Because of its ability to excite mental pictures in a temporal sequence, poetry is better able to create an illusion of reality. Thus, although strongly opposed to ekphrasis because of its mingling of painting and poetry, he nevertheless espouses the energetic creation of visual images through language.[13]

Lessing's notions of time and space have remained fundamental to the analysis of ekphrasis to this day.[14] For example, Murray Krieger's Ekphrasis*: The Illusion of the Natural Sign* (1992) defines ekphrasis as a device to "interrupt the temporality of discourse, to freeze it during its indulgence in spatial exploration" (p. 7) and his concept of the "ekphrastic principle" includes those poems which seek to emulate the pictorial or sculptural arts by achieving a kind of spatiality. But while e*kphrasis* for the Greeks implied a visual impact on the mind's eye of the listener, today the real or fictional art object itself is the occasion for the poem, which seeks to render that visual

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12 Leonardo da Vinci, *Leonardo da Vinci's Paragone: Critical Interpretation with a new Edition of the Text in the Codex Urbinas*, ed. Claire J. Farago (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1992), p. 209.

13 Alexandra Wettlaufer, *In the Mind's Eye: The Visual Impulse in Diderot, Baudelaire and Ruskin* (New York and Amsterdam: Rodopi, 2003), pp. 64-66.

14 Cf. W.J.T. Mitchell, "Space and Time: Lessing's *Laokoon* and the Politics of Genre", *Iconology: Image, Text, Ideology* (Chicago and London: U of Chicago P, 1986), pp. 95-115 (p. 97).



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object into words. Thus, ekphrasis today is generally defined as "verbal representation of a visual representation."[15]

This twentieth-century usage was coined by Leo Spitzer in 1955 in an analysis of Keats' "Ode on a Grecian Urn." There he defined ekphrasis as "the poetic description of a pictorial or sculptural work of art, which description implies, in the words of Théophile Gautier, 'une transposition d'art', the reproduction through the medium of words of sensuously perceptible *objets d'art* (*ut pictura poesis*)."[16] But inter-art comparisons, that is, comparisons between the arts, had already interested René Wellek, who, in an article in 1941 discusses "The Parallelism between Literature and the Visual Arts."[17] His position is largely a warning against going too far with analogies between the arts and against the confusion of the arts by a simple transference of terms from one art to another. Instead, he argues, critics should look for structural relationships and make use of semiology and their concepts of signs, norms and values in inter-art comparisons.

Similar cautions against generalizations and calls for factually grounded structural relationships continued to concern critics throughout the seventies and eighties. In "Art and Literature: A Plea for Humility" (1972) Jean Seznec emphasizes the need for a factual method which looks for actual contacts between art and literature, and pleads for monographic studies of precise, fully documented relationships.[18] Likewise, Ulrich Weisstein in his chapter on "Literature and the Visual Arts" in the first MLA publication dedicated to *Interrelations of Literature* (1982), is primarily concerned with guidelines to make valid inter-art comparisons. Like Seznec, he calls for monographic studies, limited in object and rigorous in form with a precise and narrow choice of topic, and "conducted in a controlled environment" in order to avoid vast syntheses and generalizations.[19] In the same year, Wendy Steiner published *The Colors of Rhetoric*, in which she proposes and illustrates a structuralist method of inter-art comparisons that seeks parallels while being aware of impossibilities of structural correspondences. Similar to Murray Krieger, Steiner defines ekphrasis as a description of a "pregnant moment in

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15 James A. W. Heffernan, *Museum of Words: The Poetics of Ekphrasis from Homer to Ashbery* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1993), p. 3.

16 Leo Spitzer, "The 'Ode on a Grecian Urn,' or Content vs. Metagrammar", *Comparative Literature* 7.3 (1955), 203-25 (p. 207).

17 René Wellek, "The Parallelism between Literature and the Visual Arts", *English Institute Annual* (New York: Columbia UP, 1941), 29-63.

18 Jean Seznec, "Art and Literature: A Plea for Humility", *New Literary History* 3.3 (1972), 569-74 (pp. 571-74).

19 Ulrich Weisstein, "Literature and the Visual Arts", in *Interrelations of Literature,* ed. Baricelli and Gibaldi (New York: MLA, 1982), pp. 251-77 (p. 267).



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painting," that is as attempt to imitate the visual arts by describing a still moment and thereby halting time.[20]

## Ekphrasis and Ideology

Whereas these critics have discussed the literature-art relationship largely as an aesthetic one, critics from the late eighties on have tended to see the relationship as socially and ideologically motivated, as a "dialectical struggle in which the opposed terms take on different ideological roles and relationships at different moments in history".[21] W.J.T. Mitchell was one of the first to discuss inter-art comparisons in terms of social relations. By showing how Lessing in his *Laokoon* connects the difference between painting and poetry to that between men and women and the English and the French influence, Mitchell demonstrates how Lessing's attempt to establish laws and borders to distinguish the arts is permeated by a rhetoric of political economy and social, gender relations. The laws of genre not only shift into laws of proper behavior for each gender, but moreover function to segregate the arts in "an imperialist design for absorption by the more dominant, expansive art".[22]

Similarly, Ernest B. Gilman has discussed this "Imperialism of Language" as central to inter-art comparisons since Antiquity, emphasizing that the paragone, or the rivalry between the arts, exists not only between the disciplines, but also between their academic exponents, art historians and literary critics. Alluding to the commonplace of painting as mute poetry and poetry as speaking picture, he concludes that "[i]f the image lurks in the heart of language as its unspeakable other, then critics should be open to the possibility that images harbor a similarly charged connection with language – as an invisible other."[23] Likewise, Grant F. Scott discusses ekphrasis as appropriation of the "visual other" and as an attempt to "transform and master the image by inscribing it."[24] Diverging from critics such as Jean Hagstrum, Leo Spitzer and Murray Krieger, who see ekphrasis as "imitation"

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20 Wendy Steiner, *The Colors of Rhetoric* (Chicago and London: U of Chicago P, 1982), p. 41.

21 Mitchell, "Space", p. 98.

22 Ibid. p. 107.

23 Ernest B. Gilman, "Interart Studies and the 'Imperialism' of Language," in *Art and Literature I,* ed. by Wendy Steiner, spec. issue of *Poetics Today* 10.1 (1989), 5-30 (p.23).

24 Grant F. Scott, "The Rhetoric of Dilation: Ekphrasis and Ideology", *Word & Image* 7.4 (1991), 301-10 (p.302).



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of the visual arts, or as "giving voice" to the image, Scott sees it as "a means of […] demonstrating dominance and power."[25]

Specifically, for critics such as Mitchell and Heffernan, this battle is often played out in terms of race and gender. Ekphrastic texts project the visual as "other to language."[26] In this process of cultural domination, "the self is understood to be an active, speaking, seeing subject, while the 'other' is projected as a passive, seen, and (usually) silent object. […] Like the masses, the colonized, the powerless and voiceless everywhere, visual representation cannot represent itself; it must be represented by discourse."[27] The "other" art is thus defined both in terms of racial otherness as the seen vs. the unmarked identity, and in terms of gender as the "expression of a duel between male and female gazes".[28]

Despite these ideological battles, Mitchell has argued that there is no essential difference between the two arts.[29] In other words, neither are the visual arts "inherently spatial, static, corporeal, and shapely," nor are "arguments, addresses, ideas, and narratives" proper to language. Although the visual and verbal media are different "at the level of sign-types, forms, materials of representation, and institutional traditions,"[30] Mitchell emphasizes that semantically, that is, in terms of "expressing intentions and producing effects in a viewer/listener, there is no essential difference between texts and images."[31] Thus, in contrast to the restrictive, cautionary warnings of earlier critics, for Mitchell "the problem is that we have not gone nearly far enough in our exploration of text-image relations."[32] The emphasis has thus not only shifted from an aesthetic to a social focus, but also from moderation to encouragement and excess.

However, as Bernhard F. Scholz has shown, the problem today is that there is also an excess of definitions, and that the concept of ekphrasis refers to a range of practices rather than to a distinct corpus or genre of texts. Ekphrasis has been variously defined as a rhetorical figure, that is, in terms of its effect on the listener; as a rhetorical exercise, that is, "as a term for a (descriptive) genre studied in terms of composition and typical subject

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25 Scott. p. 303.
26 Mitchell, *Picture Theory*, p. 163.
27 Ibid., p. 157.
28 Heffernan, p. 1.
29 Mitchell, "Space", p. 98; *Picture Theory,* pp. 159-62; and "Going Too Far With The Sister Arts", in *Space, Time, Image, Sign: Essays on Literature and the Visual Arts*, ed. by James A.W. Heffernan (New York: Peter Lang, 1987), pp. 1-10.
30 Mitchell, *Pictur Theory*, p. 161.
31 Ibid., p. 160.
32 Mitchell, "Going Too Far", p. 2.



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matter";[33] as a literary genre, "defined by reference to form and/or subject matter"; a macrostructure, "defined in syntactic terms and in terms of the materials which are ordered by the macrostructure," like "plot" or "collage"; as an intertextual relation, "defined by its characteristic relation to another text"; or broadly as a mode of writing, "to be contrasted with 'description', 'argumentation' or 'dialogue'."[34] Each of these possibilities will lead critics to emphasize different features and functions of ekphrasis. In light of this absence of consensus about what constitutes the genre of ekphrasis and how it is to be distinguished from other similar phenomena, Scholz concludes that it might be more fruitful to see it "as complex multi-dimensional multi-faceted semiotic phenomenon," as a "term with a 'family of meanings' with each member of that family calling for a separate definition."[35]

## Expanding the Definition of Ekphrasis

In fact, as Claus Clüver has argued, "contemporary ekphrastic practices have subverted the traditional relation of the representational visual text to its verbal representation, even to the point of discontinuity."[36] Thus, critics have felt the need to redefine the concept of ekphrasis, for its general definition as "verbal representation of visual representation" has been increasingly perceived as too narrow. Margaret Persin in her book on ekphrasis in 20th-century Spanish poetry (1997) has expanded the range of ekphrastic objects, discussing not only poems about paintings but also about "uncanonical art forms such as television, photography, comics, and cinematography."[37] In the same year, Claus Clüver proposes a yet more "radical revision of the concept that would lead to a considerable extension."[38] This extension consists not only in broadening the definition to include as the object of ekphrasis any discourse composed in a non-verbal sign system, but moreover, his proposal

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33 Bernhard F. Scholz., "*'Sub Oculos Subiectio'*: Quintilian on Ekphrasis and Enargeia", in *Pictures into Words: Theoretical and Descriptive Approaches to Ekphrasis*, ed. by Valerie Robillard and Els Jongeneel (Amsterdam: VU University Press, 1998), pp. 73-99 (p. 73).

34 Scholz, pp. 73-74.

35 Ibid, p. 75.

36 Claus Clüver, "Ekphrasis Reconsidered: On Verbal Representations of Non-Verbal Texts", in *Interart Poetics: Essays on the Interrelations of the Arts and Media*, ed. by Ulla-Britta Lagerroth, Hans Lund, and Erik Hedling (Amsterdam and Atlanta: Rodopi, 1997), pp. 19-33 (p. 30).

37 Margaret Persin, *Getting the Picture: The Ekphrastic Principle in Twentieth-Century Spanish Poetry* (Lewisburg: Bucknell UP; London: Associated UP, 1997), p. 19.

38 Clüver, "Ekphrasis", p. 23.



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implies that ekphrasis would also include both the tableau vivant and theatricalization,[39] two terms eminently relevant for the notion of filmic ekphrasis.

Having expanded the second part of the ekphrastic equation, Clüver proceeds to revise the first part a year later. Rather than "verbal representation" he argues for the term "verbalization" which is less tied to mimesis than the traditional term, yet retains a certain degree of *enargeia* inherent in and central to ekphrasis.[40] Thus, he defines the concept as "the verbalization of real or fictitious texts composed in a non-verbal sign system" (49). Likewise, Tamar Yacobi has shown in various essays that ekphrasis can include a mere allusion to an "ekphrastic model" or an "ekphrastic simile" of no more than one phrase.[41] Both generally invoke a pictorial model rather than a specific painting (such as *a* Last Supper, *a* Crucifixion), but produce multiple interconnections and cross-references. They thus function as "abbreviated reference to a whole pictorial set of works, which silently refers the reader to the original itself for details and extensions."[42]

The most radical re-definition, and most significant one for my purposes, has been proposed in 2000 by Siglind Bruhn in her book on *Musical Ekphrasis* and an article based on the introduction of that book a year later.[43] She expands Clüver's definition of ekphrasis to refer to the "representation in one medium of a real or fictitious text composed in another medium."[44] Musical ekphrasis can thus transpose either a painting or a literary text, and the individual studies in her book are in fact devoted to both cases. Bruhn's re-definition is particularly relevant since it contends that the "recreating medium need not always be verbal, but can itself be any of the art forms other than the one in which the primary 'text' is cast."[45] In a footnote, she

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39 Clüver, "Ekphrasis", p. 26.

40 Claus Clüver, "Quotation, Enargeia, and the Function of Ekphrasis", in *Pictures into Words: Theoretical and Descriptive Approaches to Ekphrasis*, ed. by Valerie Robillard and Els Jongeneel (Amsterdam: VU University Press, 1998), pp. 35-52 (p. 45).

41 Tamar Yacobi, "The Ekphrastic Model: Forms and Functions", in *Pictures into Words: Theoretical and Descriptive Approaches to Ekphrasis*, ed. by Valerie Robillard and Els Jongeneel (Amsterdam: VU University Press, 1998), pp. 21-34; "Verbal Frames and Ekphrastic Figuration," in *Interart Poetics: Essays on the Interrelations of the Arts and Media*, ed. byUlla-Britta Lagerroth, Hans Lund, and Erik Hedling (Amsterdam and Atlanta: Rodopi, 1997), pp. 35-46.

42 Yacobi, "Verbal", p. 42.

43 Siglind Bruhn, *Musical Ekphrasis: Composers Responding to Poetry and Painting* (Hillsdale, NY: Pendragon Press, 2000) and "A Concert of Paintings: Musical Ekphrasis in the 20th Century," *Poetics Today* 22:3 (2001): 551-605.

44 Bruhn, *Musical,* p. 8; "Concert", p. 559.

45 Bruhn, *Musical*, pp. 7-8.



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points out that Claus Clüver, in his article "On Intersemiotic Transposition" has interpreted Charles Demuth's painting *I Saw the Figure Five in Gold* as intersemiotic transposition of William Carlos William's poem "The Great Figure."[46] Not only do the third and fourth lines of the poem provide the title of the painting, but the painting does in fact transpose the poem, including its past tense, into pictorial language. Wendy Steiner, in *Pictures of Romance* provides another example of the way in which a work of art transposes a novel.[47] All of these, as Bruhn emphasizes, are cases of "visual representation of verbal representation,"[48] thus reversing Heffernan's well-known definition of ekphrasis.

## The Case for Cinematic Ekphrasis

In spite of these attempts to broaden the concept of ekphrasis, the term has not yet been applied to film as a medium that can transpose a painting. However, one need not go as far as Bruhn's re-definition to allow for the possibility of visual or filmic ekphrasis. Clüver's above-cited definition of ekphrasis as "the verbalization of real or fictitious texts composed in a non-verbal sign system" would apply equally to poetic ekphrasis as to an ekphrastic passage in the stage directions of a drama or in a screenplay. Elizabeth Drumm in her discussion of "Ekphrasis in Valle-Inclan's *Comedias bárbaras*" has shown how ekphrasis is used in the stage directions of that drama. Although the ekphrasis is a mere reference to some vague, unidentified "retratos antiguos" (old portraits), the trilogy as a whole functions as "prolonged ekphrasis of the mute art object."[49] Moreover, ekphrasis in this drama does not privilege language, but rather the "rich ambiguity" and the "persistent and inscrutable presence"[50] of the visual image.

Ekphrastic passages in such texts as dramas and screenplays will be acted out and dramatized, and thus lose their purely verbal nature. But will they then also lose their potential to be ekphrastic? I would like to extend and

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46 Claus Clüver, "On Intersemiotic Transposition", in *Art and Literature I,* ed. by Wendy Steiner, spec. issue of *Poetics Today* 10.1 (1989), 55-90.

47 Wendy Steiner, *Pictures of Romance: Form Against Context in Painting and Literature*. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988), p. 109.

48 Bruhn, *Musical*, p. 8.

49 Elizabeth Drumm, "Ekphrasis in Valle-Inclán's *Comedias bárbaras*", *Revista de Estudios Hispánicos* 34.2 (2000), 391-407 (p. 391).

50 Ibid., p. 393.



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combine Clüver's and Bruhn's above-mentioned definitions of ekphrasis to explicitly include the *quotation and dramatization* of texts in another medium to expand the possibilities of visual and cinematographic ekphrasis.[51] I therefore define ekphrasis as *the verbalization, quotation, or dramatization of real or fictitious texts composed in another sign system*.

Like Bruhn, then, I argue that ekphrasis need not be purely verbal. If the goal of verbal ekphrasis is to make the reader see, cinematic ekphrasis can also be discussed in terms of its effect on the audience. Filmic ekphrasis allows the viewer to compare the filmic representation or enactment of the art work with the actual work itself, thus creating a synthesis of the two images in the viewer's mind. With this audience-oriented goal, ekphrasis is closely tied to reception. But not only does ekphrasis strive for a creative visual effect on the audience, but moreover, it also indicates the writer's or filmmaker's interpretation, and thus reception of a work of art or an artist's oeuvre. As Gisbert Kranz has noted with regard to the ekphrastic poem and in reference to Roman Ingaarden, it is a "concretization of the work of art," a concretization which comprises both the effect produced by the work of art and the reception by the recipient.[52] Analyzing the literary and filmic reception and concretization of a work of art through their ekphrases, we can gain insight into the similarities and differences in the interpretation of famous works of art in high and in popular culture.

For this ekphrastic process, this concretization, I prefer to use Bruhn's term "transmedialization," which she coins by referring to the existence of the adjective "-medial" in German as well as French.[53] Having shown how other terms suggested by literary critics for the ekphrastic process, such as transposition, transformation, or translation, invite misreadings and possess music-specific meanings, she proposes this term as one that adequately captures the essence of that process. While this term seems to convey the same meaning as Clüver's "intersemiotic transposition" (translation or transmutation), I find "transmedialization" both simpler and more precise.

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51 However, as Clüver has emphasized with regard to ekphrasis of architecture, the existence of ekphrasis in a discourse depends both on how the object is represented, that is, as another representation or merely as object, and on the reception of its representation ("Ekphrasis Reconsidered", p. 26). Thus, it would be important to distinguish between films that merely show some art works and those in which they fulfill a narrative function.

52 Gisbert Kranz, *Das Bildgedicht. Theorie – Lexikon – Bilbiographie*, vol. 1 (Köln and Wien [Cologne and Vienna]: Böhlau Verlag, 1981), p. 158.

53 Bruhn, *Musical*, p. 51



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Moreover, its English usage is prefigured in terms such as "intermedial" and "intermediality."[54]

My own reading of films in the light of the ekphrastic process has benefited from Siglind Bruhn's analysis of musical ekphrasis, Claus Clüver's various expansions of literary ekphrasis, and Donna L. Poulton's discussion of the uses of art in film. None of these investigations, however, touches on the ability of film to transmedialize a work of art by adapting the pictorial into the cinematographic language. In fact, although there are a number of studies on film-painting relationships, none has investigated the possibility of filmic ekphrasis. However, one does not need to go as far as Zahlten and claim that the discourse between art history and film studies has largely been denied.[55] For example, Angela Dalle Vacche's anthology *The Visual Turn: Classical Film Theory and Art History* documents the "dialogue between the history of art history in the early twentieth century and the history of classical film theory"[56] and demonstrates that the boundaries between the two disciplines are beginning to disappear. However, in most of the scholarly practice today, this is not the case. Existing studies on film-art relationships generally center on documentaries about artists.[57] If feature films are considered, scholars generally either look at technical similarities between the visual arts and the movies,[58] or examine the use of paintings in one

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54 See for example the publication *Icons – Texts – Iconotexts: Essays on Ekphrasis and Intermediality*, ed. by Peter Wagner (Berlin and New York: Walter de Gruyter, 1996). The terms "intermedial" and "intermediality" are also used by Claus Clüver in his "On Intersemiotic Transposition," and Valerie Robillard in her "In Pursuit of Ekphrasis (an intertextual approach)," in *Pictures into Words: Theoretical and Descriptive Approaches to Ekphrasis*, ed. by Valerie Robillard and Els Jongeneel (Amsterdam: VU University Press, 1998), pp. 53-72.

55 Johannes Zahlten, "Die Kunsthistoriker und der Film. Historische Aspekte und künftige Möglichkeiten", in *Kunst und Künstler im Film*, ed. by Helmut Korte,and Johannes Zahlten (Hameln: Verlag C.W. Niemeyer, 1990), pp. 13-19 (p. 13).

56 Angela Dalle Vacche, "Introduction: Unexplored Connections in a New Territory", in *The Visual Turn: Classical Film Theory and Art History* (New Brunswick, NJ and London: Rutgers UP, 2003), pp. 1-29 (p. 1).

57 E.g. *Art History and Film: Starting from the Arts: A Symposium,* Boston, November 14-16, 1991 (New York: Program for Art on Film, 1992); Simon Howard Dizon, *The Image Incarnate: On the Documentary Representation of Painting in Film*, diss U of Iowa, 2000; Catherine Egan and John Egan, "Films About Artists and Their Audiences", in *The Mediazation of the Arts,* ed. by Catherine Egan, spec. issue of *Perspectives on Film* 4 (1982), 20-30; Günter Minas, *Bildende Kunst im Film der Bundesrepublik Deutschland. Ergebnisse ener Bestandsaufnahme* (Berlin: G.Minas, 1986); Jens Thiele, *Das Kunstwerk im Film* (Bern: Herbert Lang; Frankfurt a.M. and München: Peter Lang, 1976).

58 E.g. Angela Dalle Vacche, *Cinema and Painting: How Art Is Used in Film* (Austin: U of Texas P, 1996); Anne Hollander, *Moving Pictures* (New York: Knopf, 1989).



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individual film,[59] or focus on the role of the artist as portrayed in bio-pictures about famous painters, rather than on the art works themselves.[60]

## Film and Painting

Relatively few scholars have attempted to outline the various ways in which paintings can be used in film. Susan Felleman's *Art in the Cinematic Imagination* examines a range of ways in which films have incorporated works of art, using "psychoanalytical and feminist theory to uncover the meanings that the incorporation of art has for and in movies."[61] However, her study does not account for different ways in which art may be integrated and used in film, and her examples range from films in which art plays a minor role as background picture to films about artists without differentiating degrees and kinds of filmic appropriation of art.

Donna L. Poulton in her 1999 dissertation, *Moving Images in Art and Film*, has outlined sixteen categories for the intertextual integration of paintings into feature films.[62] With her focus on the quotes referring to art works in films, several of the categories she outlines could in fact represent instances of filmic ekphrasis and will be further discussed in Chapter 2. However, of the three categories she analyzes in detail, only one ("Films that directly quote paintings," i.e. in which paintings are directly shown to the

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59 E.g. Jürgen Paech., "*La belle captive* (1983). Malerei, Roman, Film (Rene Magritte / Alain Robbe-Grillet)", in *Literaturverfilmungen*, ed. by Franz-Josef Albersmeier and Volker Roloff (Frankfurt a.M.: Suhrkamp 1989), pp. 409-436; and Gerd Bauer, "Jean-Luc Godard: Ausser Atem/A Bout de Souffle (Frankreich 1959)", in *Kunst und Künstler im Film*, ed. by Helmut Korte and Johannes Zahlten (Hameln: Verlag C.W. Niemeyer, 1990), pp. 111-121.

60 E.g. Ellen Fischer, "Das Künstlerbild im amerikanischen Spielfilm der 50er und 60er Jahre," in *Film, Fernsehen, Video und die Künste: Strategien der Intermedialität*, ed. by Joachim Paech (Stuttgart and Weimar: Verlag J.B. Metzler, 1994), pp. 103-113; and John A. Walker, *Arts & Artists on Screen* (Manchester and New York: Manchester UP, 1993). Helmut Korte's "Kunstwissenschaft – Medienwissenschaft: Methodologische Anmerkungen zur Filmanalyse", in *Kunst und Künstler im Film*, ed. by Helmut Korte and Johannes Zahlten (Hameln: Verlag C.W. Niemeyer, 1990), pp. 21-42 is somewhat of an exception, since it is concerned with methodological problems in the analysis of films about artists, in the course of which he briefly discusses several such films. However, his analysis does not pertain specifically to the transmedialization of the art work in the film, but rather aims at an overall interpretation of the film.

61 Susan Felleman, *Art in the Cinematic Imagination* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2006), p. 2.

62 Donna Lauren Poulton, *Moving Images in Art and Film: The Intertextual and Fluid Use of Painting in Cinema* (diss Brigham Young University, 1999).



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viewer) could classify as ekphrastic, while the other two neither require a (real, fictional, or tableau vivant) image to be used, nor do these films provide any verbal discourse about art.

In contrast to the films Poulton discusses, fiction features about artists, usually do include some verbal as well as visual representation of artworks.[63] Yet, John A. Walker, the only scholar so far to have undertaken an extensive analysis of such bio-pictures, claims that in focusing on the biography of an individual artist, these films generally neglect the artwork or interpret it as merely an aspect of the artist's personality and biography.[64] Although this may be true for some biographical features, I contend that this negative assessment can be challenged and qualified by comparing the ekphrastic use of painting in feature films about art and artists with its function in literary texts.

Furthermore, I maintain that it is essential for a full understanding of ekphrasis in films to distinguish it from the genre of biographical feature films. Cinematic ekphrasis is neither synonymous with nor a subgroup of bio-features, but can occur in other feature films as well. Moreover, my use of the term filmic ekphrasis refers only to particular scenes or sequences, rather than signifying a filmic genre. In contrast to ekphrastic poems, which more easily classify as a genre due to the compact nature of poetry, in most novels, dramas and films, ekphrasis will take up only a quantitatively small aspect of the whole work, insufficient to classify as genre.[65] So unlike Bruhn's claim with regard to ekphrastic music,[66] I do not allege that filmic ekphrasis represents a separate genre of films.

In his essay "Film and Painting" André Bazin also takes up the criticism against films about art works. Bazin argues that these films are both didactically useful (by bringing the masses to appreciate art and by bringing together high and popular culture) and, by uniting high and popular culture within themselves, a work of art in their own right. As Bazin emphasizes,

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63 Of course there are some exceptions, such as James Ivory's *Surviving Picasso* (1996) or Robert Altman's *Vincent and Theo* (1990) both of which feature very few representations of paintings and very little of the discussions revolve about art.

64 Walker, p.19.

65 Again, there are some exceptions, in which a whole novel or drama could be considered ekphrastic, for example Antonio Buero Vallejo's drama *El sueño de la razón* (of which I will discuss only one scene in chapter three), E.T.A. Hoffmann's novella *Prinzessin Brambilla*, which is inspired by a series of etchings by Jacques Callot, Gert Hofmann's *Der Blindensturz* (1985), a book-length narrative that verbalizes Brueghel's *The Parable of the Blind*, and Pierre Ajame's *La laitière de Bordeaux d'après le tableau de Fransisco Goya* (1985), a novella inventing the story behind Goya's *Milkmaid of Bordeaux*.

66 Bruhn, *Musical*, pp. xvii-xix.



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"[t]he film of a painting is an aesthetic symbiosis of screen and painting."[67] Moreover, he concludes by comparing films about art, such as Resnais' *Guernica* and *Van Gogh*, or Pierre Kast's *Goya*, to "a certain type of literary criticism which is likewise a re-creation – Baudelaire on Delacroix, Valery [sic.] on Baudelaire, Malraux on Greco."[68] What Bazin is here referring to is various cases of ekphrasis that fall between literature and art history. By indicating that films about art are comparable to that type of ekphrasis, Bazin emphasizes that these films are, like their literary counterparts, aesthetically valuable as well as valuable pieces of art criticism, that is, criticism that is itself a work of art.

Just like literary ekphrasis, its filmic counterpart also relates to the formal, stylistic aspects of the re-presentation of the art work through cinematographic devices. Unlike the purely verbal nature of most literary ekphrases, however, film has at its disposal verbal, visual and auditory (e.g. background noises, music) means with which to transmedialize a painting. Thus, the discourse of filmic ekphrasis can be constituted by both of the sign systems (the verbal and the visual) that are separate and often in competition in a literary ekphrasis. In other words, filmic ekphrasis reenacts in the cinematographic medium itself the antagonism between word and image that is central to the tradition of ekphrasis. In literary ekphrasis, as in films, it is often the visual elements that revalue or subvert the written/spoken word. Likewise, just as literary ekphrasis often uses the discourse about the image as a self-reflective statement on its own status in comparison to the visual image, so can the insertion of works of art into a film function as a self-referential comment on the film as a "moving image" and its relationship to the silent, static image. This is particularly the case with films that embody pictures in *tableaux vivants*,[69] with which film often "seeks to outdo" the static visual representations, and "in the process, it defines its own modalities."[70]

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67 Bazin, p. 168.

68 Ibid., p. 169.

69 The *tableau vivant*, the "static embodiment of well-known paintings by human actors" has a twofold origin, one of which are Diderot's bourgeois tragedies, "a paradigmatic moment of dramatic intensification during which the actors hold their poses and all motion on the stage ceases." The other origin is pornographic, derived from an eighteenth-century sex therapist. Cf. Brigitte Peucker, "Filmic Tableau Vivant: Vermeer, Intermediality, and the Real", in *Rites of Realism: Essays on Corporeal Cinema*, ed. by Ivone Margulies (Durham, NC and London: Duke UP, 2003), pp. 294-314 (p. 294).

70 Brigitte Peucker, *Incorporating Images: Film and the Rival Arts* (Princeton: Princeton UP, 1995), p. 6.



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However, as my analyses in the chapters that follow will show, filmic ekphrasis is not only verbal and visual. My analysis will demonstrate that it can also be auditory, thus adding another sign system to the filmic representation of a work of art, and potentially further heightening the tension and interconnections between sign systems. Moreover, filmic ekphrasis can forgo all verbal discourse in favor of a purely visual and auditory one, examples of which will be discussed in the following chapters. Thus, an analysis of ekphrastic scenes or sequences in film is linked to questions such as how the various sign systems are interrelated within one medium, if and why film privileges one over the other, and how the various sign systems can interact to interpret another artistic medium.

Placing selected feature films about art and artists in the tradition of ekphrasis, I explore what the use of paintings in films implies about the social roles of art. Who speaks about art and in what contexts? How does art function in films to convey social or economic positions? Does the relationship between ekphrasis and social power change from text to film? Comparing filmic treatments of paintings by Vermeer, Rembrandt, and Goya with ekphrases in literary texts, I will examine if and how the medium of ekphrasis (i.e. literary or filmic) alters the representation of the visual arts, in order to show what the similarities or differences imply about issues such as the function of art for the construction of a personal and/or social identity and gender roles. Do writers and filmmakers ascribe the same or different roles to the function of words and images, of speaking and looking? Does the concept of the *paragone*, the rivalry between words and images, intensify or lose relevance in filmic ekphrasis due to film's status as a hybrid medium?

In order to delineate how depictions of a particular painter's works differ in literary and cinematic discourse, that is, how the medium shapes the interpretation of a particular work of art, I propose to discuss ekphrases of artworks by well-known painters who are widely represented in literature and film. I believe that the creative process by which a painting is transformed into a poem or a narrative text can usefully be compared to the transformation of a painting to its cinematic rendering. Just as Siglind Bruhn has shown with regard to musical ekphrasis, I allege that the literary and filmic rendering of a painting "correspond to a degree that justifies adapting the terminology of ekphrasis developed in the literary field."[71] In Chapter Two I will therefore develop and discuss a system of ekphrastic categories and discuss how they apply to literary texts as well as to films. With the help of these categories, I describe varying forms and degrees of ekphrasis in

[71] Bruhn, "Concert", p. 559.



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order to provide and illustrate a vocabulary for analyzing the similarities and differences of ekphrasis in literature and film. This vocabulary refers to ways in which authors and filmmakers can use the visual arts as well as to degrees of involvement with them. In comparing the use of ekphrasis in three literary genres and film, I will show what different types of ekphrasis predominate in each genre and why, and what the predominance of certain categories implies with regard to the relationship between words and images in film and literary texts. As these comparisons will demonstrate, filmic ekphrases often reveal similar power structures as those of literary texts, despite the fact that cinema is a hybrid genre itself. Analyzing the similarities and differences between literary and filmic ekphrasis, then, will provide insight into the various dynamics of words and images in different genres. Furthermore, in discussing ekphrasis as a form of reception, this comparison will also highlight the ways in which popular, well-known works of high art are received in other high art media (poetry, novels, and drama) as well as popular culture (here represented by film).

As a segue into the discussion of these categories and their application to film, I discuss the German photographer Thomas Struth's series of *Museum Photographs* as examples of ekphrasis represented visually. The following four chapters deal with the representation of selected works of art, and focus on social vs. aesthetic concerns, and issues of gender. In order to minimize the scope and range of my study, and thus the danger of generalizations, I have limited myself not only to a controlled sample of three artists, Goya, Rembrandt, and Vermeer, but even further, to only one work of art or a clearly identifiable group by each: Goya's *Capricho 43: El sueño de la razón produce monstrous*, Rembrandt's self-portraits, and Vermeer's paintings of single women, particularly *Girl with a Pearl Earring* and *Woman with a Pearl Necklace*.

The first three analyses largely focus on aesthetic and socio-political concerns, looking at ekphrases on works by Goya and Rembrandt. In chapter three, I discuss how Goya's *Capricho 43*, *El sueño de la razón produce monstrous*, is used in a poem, a drama, and a film. Chapter four continues this analysis of Goya's etching in a novel and its film version. In all of them, ekphrasis functions as a dramatization of the parallel between private-aesthetic and socio-political conflicts and the artist's ability to control them with his art. In chapter five, on Rembrandt's self-portraits, I analyze the role of ekphrasis as dramatization of the painter's self-clarification in a screenplay and a film. Here, I show how the film tends to intensify the screenplay's interpretation of the artist's public role play through his self portraits, and uses cinematic re-constructions of those self portraits to create its own



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version of "Rembrandt." In the last chapter I turn to gender issues. Chapter six examines two novels and films about Vermeer, analyzing how the novels use ekphrasis for female empowerment, whereas the films revert to the traditional male gaze and voice and a more socio-political role of art. In comparing the changes of the film adaptations of Tracy Chevalier's *Girl with a Pearl Earring* and Susan Vreeland's *Girl in Hyacinth Blue* with regard to degree and kind as well as point of view of the ekphrastic scenes, I show how the films underscore the socio-political implications of art and use ekphrasis to demonstrate male power, while the novels use it as space of female self-realization.

In the concluding chapter seven I attempt to draw some inferences from the preceding chapters and discuss whether film does in fact appropriate the image by giving it a voice as well as a living body in representing it as a tableau, for example, or whether it allows the image to signify on its own by representing it visually. What are the different implications of purely verbal as opposed to mostly visual ekphrasis? And how do the four different ekphrastic categories (attributive, depictive, interpretive, and dramatic) affect the interpretation of the work of art? In so far as ekphrasis can be said to be a self-reflective genre, to what degree are the four categories self-referential, and what role does the paragone play in visual, filmic ekphrasis?



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